

Research Centre (www.sirc.org) is anything to go by.

Apparently, in a study of 2,500 Web surfers, a new type of disease—now dubbed Mouse Rage Syndrome—was discovered. The researchers tested to see what type of online experience could result in heightened stress levels, indicated by a faster heart-beat, increased perspiration, furious mouse clicking, and in some cases, the losing of control and the screaming at monitors.

For Western users, such experiences can be blamed on badly-designed sites, or those hosted on really slow servers. The test started with making users experience what the researchers thought was “the perfect Web site”—good layout, fast loading, easy navigation, etc. Next, they moved the users on to slow loading sites with ugly graphics and basically badly designed sites. This was when they noted changes in body language, heart rates and overall gauged the users stress levels. While some stayed calm, most showed negative

No Smoking Please!

This month, we all decided to take up smoking! Now now, before you chide us for making tobacco companies richer, take a look at the Digital Passion > Lead Feature story... Yes, we were all inhaling lots of sweet smelling incense smoke, courtesy Fatbeing (Nimish), Raaabo, The Browne and Vijay “PJ” Padaya.

At least the smokers in the team can now stop cribbing about not being allowed to smoke *inside* the office!

As of writing this, which is a week after the “smoking,” most of us still get the taste of incense in everything we drink or eat.

Apart from that, we had a lot of feigned-sicknesses—no doubt the aftermath of a rather hectic December issue. Deepak was convinced that most of us had taken some part-

time acting classes.

There was more multi-player *Quake III Arena*, much to Deepak’s dismay, with Sanket and Agent001 joining in to put Raaabo back in his place. The rest of us still got fragged like hell, but it was so worth it to see Raaabo lose miserably as the two best *Quakers* in the office taught him some humility.

Deepak had to take a trip into town during rush hour—he had applied for a US visa for business—and swallowed more smoke in the traffic jams than we did during our smoking experiment. He claims it was worth it, though, because he got a 10-year visa!

Rumour now has it that we will soon be looking for a replacement editor, unless he actually comes back in January after his business trip! We’ll wait and see...

DIGIT DIARY

effects to the heart as well as the nervous and immune systems.

Now, while we’re waiting for the first “you killed me / my relative / my friend with bad site design” lawsuit to be reported from the West, we can all sit back and curse our luck.

Most of us probably

have been suffering from Mouse Rage Syndrome for some time now, but it has nothing to do with the sites themselves—but rather the pathetically slow speeds that we have to make do with here in India. We know for a fact that normally, lightning-fast sites can take ages to open

on even our 128 / 256 Kbps connections here in India, but perhaps the saddest part is that we can’t sue just anyone, like Westerners can! All we can do is tell you about this latest disease, ask you to calm down and take a breath or two. Don’t let your ISP kill you... literally! ■

Blog WATCH

Google, Web 2.0, and iPhone. Boring because the same topics keep popping up again and again—but some people’s takes can be interesting

Mark Cuban

<http://snipurl.com/jan001>
(<http://www.blogmaverick.com/2006/12/12/googlencmic-itunes-and-zune/>)

Googlenomics, iTunes and Zune

... Would it be worth it to Google to pay \$575 m and up per year to completely turn Apple upside down? To completely pre-empt their ability to sell iPods? To potentially introduce a new hardware device, or partner with someone who has one? To sell advertising around the music rather than the music itself? Is their a traditional Google arb here of 70c per song vs 70c of advertising around the song? Could it sell that much advertising online to justify giving the music away?...

Alex Iskold

<http://snipurl.com/jan002>
(http://www.readwriteweb.com/archives/2006_web_technology_trends.php)

2006 Web Technology Trends

...Undoubtedly 2006 has been the year of the social network. MySpace, YouTube, Facebook have been the three outstanding success stories—but also impressive was Bebo (in the UK particularly) and there was strong growth in existing web 2.0 networks

like Flickr and del.icio.us. The zenith of this social networking craze was probably Google buying YouTube for \$1.65 B.

... RSS continues to inch towards the mainstream—Yahoo integrated it into Y! Mail Beta, Microsoft is utilizing it more (e.g. integrated into IE7), Google came out with Google Base and the GData format (which is based on the RSS variant, ATOM). While 2006 can’t be seen as the breakthrough year for RSS in the mainstream, we will probably see RSS bloom in 2007 as a result of the groundwork done in ‘06 by the big Internet companies. Note that there have been recent murmurs that Yahoo is scaling back RSS, but I think this is a short-term trend only...

Dan Frakes

<http://snipurl.com/jan005>
(<http://www.macworld.com/weblogs/editors/2006/12/flop/index.php?lsrc=editorsblog>)

The iPhone a flop? Let’s wait and see

Let’s assume, just for a moment, that Apple really is planning on releasing an “iPhone,” a combination of a mobile phone, portable media player, and, possibly, a PDA. Will it be a big hit? Hugely successful? Who knows. I personally think it’s unlikely such a product would approach the popularity of the iPod. But I don’t think it would do nearly as poorly as Kanellos predicts.